

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, May 6, 2014

The meeting convened at 7:03 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joseph Pipczynski, Celeste Whiting, Edward Zawacki.

Visitors: Phil Dowling, Bill Tracy

1. Reviewed minutes from 4/8/14. Amended minutes to note that all budget line item numbers refer to the 4/8/14 budget. The line item numbers have since changed. Voted 7-0-0 to accept the minutes as amended. (Two committee members arrived after this vote.
2. Transfer request from selectboard. We reviewed the transfer request for counsel fees and discussed whether to transfer the request of \$3,000 or transfer additional funds to cover next month's counsel fees so that we will not have to reconvene for an additional transfer. We voted 8-0-1 to transfer \$6,000 from the Reserve Fund.
3. Reviewed correspondence: We received a letter regarding the transportation bids. This item was tabled.
We received a letter regarding bids for the school roof. We noted that the bids are considerably less than the original proposed amount. We raised a question of whether the school doors are included in these bids as there is no indication in the letter whether they are. As we move forward with this roof project, we must add approximately \$50,000 into the budget or make a tax rate adjustment. Since all proposals were significantly below cost, this will shorten the loan for the town. We raised a question of who should point out these numbers at town meeting. Bill Tracy said that he would raise this at town meeting.
4. Reviewed budget and articles. Please note: all budget line items below refer to the final proposed budget on 5/6/14.

Ellice plans on delivering an opening statement to explain the tough budget process and emphasize that if we add anything to the budget, we need to make cuts in other places.

Line # 44: We had listed \$50,000 for vocational transportation. The bids came in and the new amount is \$55,076. We will need to adjust the budget to accommodate the additional \$5,076.

Line # 45: We reviewed the budget process with regard to the elementary school. The initial request was for a 12.88% increase. FinCom voted to increase the budget by 7%. With the pothole money received, this reflects a 10% increase over last year's budget.

Line # 11 (Article 16): Discussed the IT contract. We reviewed that we didn't feel comfortable approving the full amount requested for IT services that we were not convinced were crucial at this time. FinCom approved \$1,000 for an initial IT assessment from Northeast IT. Celeste will discuss FinCom's position on article 16 at town meeting.

Line # 38: Highway Truck: Joe will speak to this item at town meeting.

Line # 45: Elementary School: Bill Tracy explained the process of making a motion and amending the motion during the meeting. We anticipate that someone will make a motion to increase the amount that FinCom recommended for the elementary school in this budget. Maryanne will speak to this at town meeting.

We discussed Free Cash. Ellice noted that a healthy town puts aside 3-5% of their annual town budget for Free Cash. We are not close to that. In addition, loan officers look at a town's Free Cash when assessing a town during a loan application. If we use too much Free Cash to balance the budget, it could adversely affect the highway truck loan process. Additionally, we would need to make up the money next year. If the town votes to fully fund the elementary school, this would require a special town meeting and a 2 1/2% override or cuts.

Line # 67: Maryanne will speak on SCBAs.

Line # 77-80: Foothills Health District. Our current health agent works for us on Fridays and is compensated \$8,800 per year. She suggested that we join the Foothills Health district so that she would be available to the town all week. Joining the Foothills would cost the town \$14,544 (part of which may be offset by the increase in fees). If we vote to stay with our current arrangement and not join the Foothills Health District, then we need to add the \$8,800 back into the budget.

Line # 77: Board of Health salary. FinCom recommended to reduce the current Board of Health salaries of \$1,800 to \$300 (\$600 to \$100 per person). We recommended this as the Board of Health has fewer responsibilities now since we have a health agent and the transfer station duties have been moved to a different department. Aniko will explain the Board of Health salary change. We noted that this will be addressed in Article 5 when we are voting to set town salaries.

Line # 126 (Free Cash) and 134 (Levy Limit): Ellice will address these in her opening remarks.

We reviewed the warrant. We discussed who will make a motion or address these articles should questions arise during the meeting.

Article 3: Bill Tracy will address.
Article 6: Ellice will make her opening remarks.
Article 9 (Elementary School): Maryanne will address.
Article 10 (Vocational Tuition): Jackie to make a motion.
Article 11(Vocational Transportation): Mary to make a motion.
Article 14 (Foothills Health District): Selectboard to address.
Article 15: Tied to article 3.
Article 16 (IT): Celeste to address.
Article 17 (short term borrowing). State says we don't need to include this article.
Article 18 (SCBAs): Maryanne to address.
Articles 19, 20, 21: All tied to article 3.
Article 22 (Free Cash): Ellice to address.
Article 23 (Highway Truck): David Blakesley to address.
Article 24 (Animal Control): Selectboard to address.
Article 25 and 26 (Bylaws): Selectboard to address.

5. Next Meeting: Tuesday, June 10, 2014 at 7:00 PM

Ellice thanked everyone for their dedication.

Meeting adjourned at 9:15 PM.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary